Well Done!

Phew. That was a lot to take in; kudos for making it this far! The string functions of PHP are numerous and varied, have several conventions (not always intuitive), and have clearly evolved over many years and major versions. You'll most likely use just a handful of them on a daily basis if you choose PHP programming as part of your career or set of hobbies. There is *no* shame in not having memorized this lot (and beware any person or organization that expects you to have done so, frankly). The full documentation is available here: `https://www.php.net/manual/en/ref.strings.php`. It is far more important that you learn the underlying principles of what text data really is. I hope this chapter (and other relevant sections of the book) is helping you in that regard.

The `mbstring` Extension

Hopefully by now the differences in encoding systems are well embedded, and you'll have some familiarity with Unicode and its transfer formats, particularly UTF-8. The previous section focused on the core string functions of PHP, how they behave at a binary level, and how they cope with multi-byte data. It also featured functions from the `mbstring` extension where they exist as equivalents to core functions. There are several more functions provided by `mbstring` that don't have core equivalents and will be discussed here, but first let's have a very quick look at `mbstring` as a language extension.

Like other PHP extensions (aka modules), `mbstring` is typically included in most prepackaged PHP installers and prebuilt Docker images. To check that `mbstring` is available in your PHP installation, simply run the following command in a Linux environment:

```
$ php -m
[PHP Modules]
...
mbstring
```

You can also check the output of `phpinfo()` if running under a web server SAPI. If `mbstring` is not listed, general guidance for module installation is covered in Chapter 1, "Getting Started."